

You can convert any video clip into an interactive puzzle. VLC changes your video into blocks and shuffles them around, while you need to join the pieces together to get the video back to its original format. Open the Video Effects tab and go to Geometry. Put a check on Puzzle game, and start playing.

Creating a video wallpaper

VLC has the feature to use the DirectX capabilities of your graphics solution and use it as a video output mode. First, get rid of your existing wallpaper. Go to **Tools > Preferences** from the menu bar and click on Video on the left. Select DirectX Video Output from the drop down list displayed next to Output and click on Save. Now start up a video and go to Video on the menu bar and click on DirectX Wallpaper.

IrfanView

The next essential software we are going to give you tips and tricks about is IrfanView, one of the most simplest and fastest image explorers available. We're not going to tell you about the basics that are possible with IrfanView, but instead we're going to tell you about some things you could do with IrfanView, that you ordinarily wouldn't use a software like IrfanView for.

RIOTing with IrfanView

RIOT stands for Radical Image Optimisation Tool and is a very useful plug-in for IrfanView. With this plug-in you can optimise images for the web. Basically, when you save an image, you can choose saving options and also the file size. Go to <http://www.irfanview.com/>

plugins.htm and download **iv_formats.zip** that contains the RIOT plug-in. Once installed, modify the images you plan to use for the web. Click on the Save for

Web option under File in the menu bar.

Next, select between JPEG, GIF and PNG. Under JPEG, you can use the quality slider to increase or decrease the quality of the image. Under GIF, you can adjust the slider to change the colours from 2 to 256 colours and you also have the option to save it as an interlaced image. With PNG, there are no sliders to adjust, but you can change the Colour reduction by selecting it from the drop down.

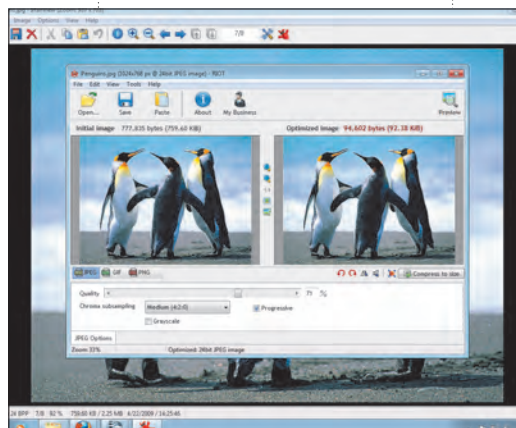
With JPEG and GIF images, you have the option to compress the image you are about to save. For this, click on the Compress to size button towards the right side of the window. Input the value of the size you want (in kB) and click on OK. RIOT automatically makes changes to the quality for JPEG, and colours for GIF and will give you an outcome with the

desired size.

There are two viewing panes, one displays the original image, while the other displays the optimised image. The area between the two holds buttons



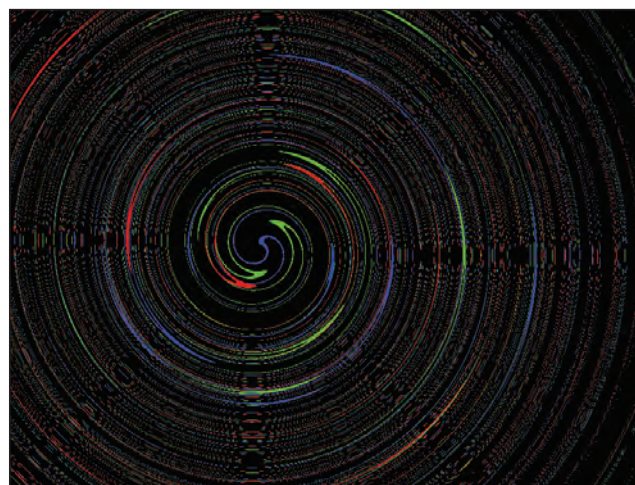
The paint dialog most of us are familiar with



The RIOT interface when you click on Save for Web



The pattern made with the Emboss tool in IrfanView



Create really funky designs with the Swirl effect

for zoom, actual view, fit to window and in-place compare.

Abstract patterns

You can create abstract patterns or images by using various filters in IrfanView. You can either use an existing image or create a new one. Go to **Edit > Show Paint** dialog from the menu bar to see IrfanView's paint tools.

Create a new image by pressing **[Ctrl] + [N]**. Select the Rectangle Tool and set the foreground colour to white. Set the pixel width to about 5 pixels. Next randomly create rectangles of different shapes around your canvas. After that apply the Emboss filter by going to **Image >**

Effects > Emboss. Now use the Sharpen filter. To do this, just press **Shift + [S]** a number of times till you see a pattern form. Next for a bit of finishing, you can go to **Image > Effects > Oil Paint** to smoothen out the edges.

You can try different filter combinations or colours and create these abstract patterns of your own.

Two other effect filters we are fond of are the Twirl and Swirl effects. We've found an interesting way to use these with a similar method as mentioned above. Instead of using a single white colour, use different colours for different rectangles and fill the canvas. Next, go to **Images > Effects > Effect Browser** and select Swirl or Twirl, and your artwork is ready!